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From a demographic perspective, new immigrants, non-local students, graduates and employees have been driving the demand for private residential units.



In general, the Fed rate and corresponding mortgage rate hike remains one of the key swing factors of the physical market. Hong Kong banks have been reducing mortgage spread from HIBOR (HK Interbank Rate) +170bps in 4Q15 to HIBOR +128bps in March 2017, to offset the 50bps Fed rate hike since December 2016. It is worth noting that room for a mortgage rate spread cut has been reducing – both the speed and magnitude of the spread cuts are declining.

Morgan Stanley's US economists are assuming six more rate hikes in the US by end-2018. If this were to happen and if HIBOR follows a similar trend to the Fed (due to the US peg), the local mortgage rate could double from the current level and could impact not only new buyers but also existing owners.

Despite brisk sales at Cullinan West and the Kai Tak area this year, we estimate residential prices will drop by 5% in 2017 driven by higher rates, increasing supply, rising risk of cooling measures and competition for land from Chinese developers, all driving margins lower.

These risks can be mitigated by higher global reflation and economic growth. For example, a 5% annual salary growth can offset 50bps of mortgage rate hikes from an affordability ratio point of view. ☺

一般而言，美國聯邦儲備銀行利率和相應的按揭利率上調，依然是現貨市場波動的關鍵因素之一。為抵消美國聯邦儲備銀行自2016年12月起利率上調合共50點子，香港銀行已多次調低按揭利率：從2015年第4季的香港銀行同業拆息+170點子，下調至2017年3月的香港銀行同業拆息+128點子。值得注意的是，調低按揭利率的空間正在收窄，其速度及幅度均有所放緩。

摩根士丹利的美國經濟師預期，美國將在2018年年底前6度加息。如果預測正確，香港銀行同業拆息會因聯繫匯率而跟隨美國聯邦儲備銀行加息，本地按揭利率則會在目前水平的基礎上翻倍，而影響新買家及現有業主。

儘管匯豐及啟德地區新樓盤交投暢旺，但我們預期2017年住宅單位價格將下跌5%。高利率、供應增加、遏制樓市過熱的風險上升，以及中國發展對土地的競爭日益增加等，都會導致利潤縮窄。

這些風險，可以通過全球通貨再膨脹及經濟增長得以舒緩。比如說，從負擔能力比率出發，每年5%的薪酬增長，足以抵消50個點子的按揭利率上調。☺